

THE ISLAND OF RAPA NUI

On an island in the middle of the Pacific Ocean, around 900 monumental statues called *moai* dominate the landscape. This island is Rapa Nui, also known as Easter Island because its first European visitor arrived on Easter Sunday in 1722. The statues were erected between 800 and 1200 CE by Polynesian people. By the late 18th century, most of the statues had been toppled. Work to reerect them began in 1960.



Remote island

The island of Rapa Nui is one of the most isolated in Polynesia, a group of 1,000 islands in the Pacific Ocean. Rapa Nui is part of Chile, which is more than 2,175 miles (3,500 km) away.

Giants of Rapa Nui

The colossal *moai* statues that dot Rapa Nui were thought to represent spirits of important ancestors. They faced inland to watch over and protect the islanders. Most of the statues are 13 ft (4 m) high but some are as tall as 33 ft (10 m). Some stand alone, others are arranged in lines.



Discovering the eye

In 1978, archaeologists found pieces of white coral while excavating a *moai*. They realized it had to be an eye when it fitted into the *moai*'s eye socket. This eye—the only original one—is on display in the Sebastián Englert Museum on Rapa Nui.



Dance paddle

Dance ceremonies were an important part of Rapa Nui culture. During dances, both men and women wielded pairs of dance paddles called *rapa*. The *rapa* were spun on axes carried by the dancers.

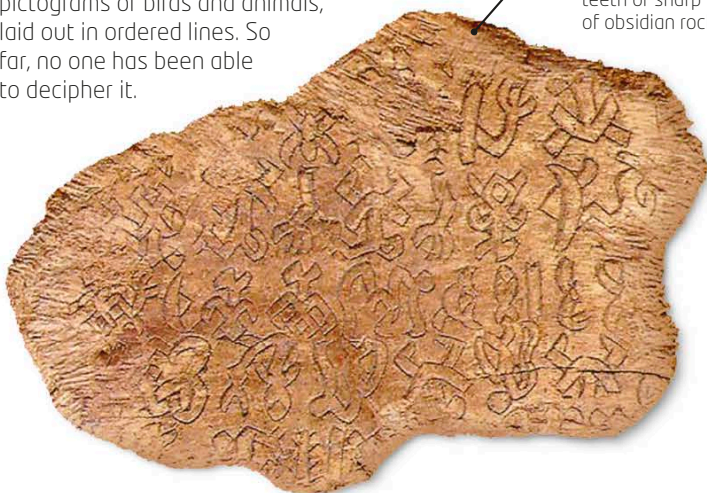
This end of the paddle represents a face, with earrings on either side.

This end of the paddle represents a person's body.

Lost language

A writing system has been found at Rapa Nui, carved into pieces of wood. It is called *rongorongo* and features hundreds of pictograms of birds and animals, laid out in ordered lines. So far, no one has been able to decipher it.

Pictograms were carved into the wood using shark teeth or sharp pieces of obsidian rock.



Canoes

The Polynesians were expert ship builders, navigators, and sailors. They made voyages of thousands of miles around the Pacific Ocean in wooden canoes. Today the people of Rapa Nui honor this tradition by racing in reed canoes.

